nineteenth century swadeshi efforts had shifted from industrial production towards banking, insurance, and inland trade—areas where profits appeared easier to make. It was a matter of general complaint that ‘the banks under European management did not afford the requisite help to Indian concerns.’[6] The establishment of the People’s Bank of India in Lahore in 1901, and the Indian Specie Bank Ltd in Bombay in 1906, owed their birth to the swadeshi upsurge backed by the handsome profits arising out of a boom in agricultural exports. Numerous banking companies appeared in western India, Punjab and the United Provinces but not all of these owed their existence to swadeshi. Many of them were promoted with the desire to share part of the huge profits made by the European banks.

Sorabji too was influenced by swadeshi and he emphasized that the discrimination he had suffered was ‘significant only because it was simultaneously an unacceptable slur on Indians and India.’[7] It was agreed that the new bank would benefit from having some prominent Indians on its Board of Directors. To this end persons like Lalubhai Samaldas, Purshotamdas Thakurdas, Phiroze Sethna, Manmohandas Ramji, and Fazalbhoy Chinoy were sounded.[8] Predictably their response was one of astonishment and skepticism, for not only was the idea revolutionary in itself, the fact that its progenitor was a youth of only twenty-eight made it even more surprising. They marshalled the usual arguments against Sorabji’s venture explaining why it was doomed to failure: it would not be able to survive the competition, the experience of other Indian banks had not been encouraging, and that the new bank was nothing more than a pipe dream.

Despite this setback Sorabji was undeterred. Along the way he had to face the sarcasm and taunts of his friends and even some relatives who were convinced that his fantastic scheme was the product of an unbalanced mind. But for Sorabji there was no turning back. He decided that he had had enough and resigned his job from the Bank of India. The uproar which followed when he broke the news of his resignation to his family was greater than anything else he had faced in the past. But for his family, familiar with what they considered his permanent impetuosity, this was the last straw. They reminded him of the dangers of the path he had chosen and warned him against throwing security and prudence to the winds. Sorabji may have felt a twinge of doubt given the fact that his family’s doubts were